But some of the punishments were extreme, and in many cases, the city had never levied penalties before. It was hard to see the crackdown as anything but a punitive measure. “It seems that the municipality is basically using collective punishment against some of the most disenfranchised members of Jerusalem’s population,” said Sarit Michaeli, a spokeswoman for B’Tselem, the Israeli rights group.

Bombs and buyers

Not much survived the explosion in the Shalloudi apartment: an empty tub of hummus, a single slipper, a few decorative tiles in the kitchen. Shalloudi lived with his parents and five siblings at the base of the hill in Silwan. Their living room, which enjoys a scenic view of the Dome of the Rock, was a rubble-strewn expanse with no walls when I visited in late November.

Nearly a month after his hit-and-run attack, dozens of paramilitary border policemen arrived at the family home in the dead of night. They emptied the five-story apartment block, set charges, and blew up the flat. The whole affair was over in a matter of hours; the Shalloudi home was completely destroyed, and the blast caused minor damage to other apartments. A slab of concrete crushed a car parked on the street below. “The explosion was loud enough to wake all of Silwan,” said his uncle, Talaat, the next morning. “They didn’t even let the children take their belongings.”

There were two stories that winter, both in Silwan, both related to housing, that undercut the notion of a united capital. On one side were the punitive home demolitions, which the Israeli government argues are a useful deterrent to Palestinian attackers. “When you’re dealing with people who have no qualms whatsoever about killing themselves in order to kill others, deterrence is a problem,” said Mark Regev, a spokesman for the prime minister (and later the Israeli ambassador in London). “How do you deter someone who’s willing to kill themselves in order to get others?”

An Israeli army commission had studied that question more than a decade ago, though, and had concluded that home demolitions were not the answer: it had found they had little deterrent value. The panel, headed by Gen Udi Shani and convened as the second intifada died down in late 2004, was the first serious study on the subject, and its findings were stark. “There is no proof of the deterrent effect of house demolitions,” it reported, after speaking with everyone from military officers to philosophers. As a result,